

fish ponds. One year later, Marcia and her children moved back into Cato's household, where it is widely believed Cato remarried her. Now, I'm not calling Marcia a gold digger, but it's clear she did pretty well for herself and her kids.

Historically speaking, marriage has always been a practical affair. So when did love start to win over practicality and financial prudence? Who's responsible for the shift to foolishness? For that, we have the Victorians to thank. In the late 1800s, people fell madly in love with the notion of romantic love. Love matches gained cultural currency, and around the turn of the 20th century, mutual attraction became a part of the equation for the first time in history. Young people shocked their parents by refusing to marry the Mr. or Ms. Wonderful to whom they were betrothed, running off instead to elope with Mr. or Ms. Morally Questionable and Officially Bankrupt.

Take the case of Alfred Gilbert, an English sculptor during the late 19th century. At 22, Alfred defied his parents and eloped to Paris with his cousin Alice, the so-called love of his life. It didn't end well. In under a decade, bankruptcy forced Alfred to flee the country, leaving Alice alone with their five children. She left him in 1904 and spent the rest of her life in a mental hospital. No storybook ending there. And maybe even a sign of things to come.

Which brings us to the present. By the time the 20th century rolled around, love matches in the Western world were fast becoming the norm. Marriage moved out of the realm of arranged social contracts and into the realm of romance and sexual desire. You know what else skyrocketed around the same time? The divorce rate.

It's no coincidence. Numerous studies have shown that, in every single society around the globe, as soon as a culture that is widely supportive of arranged marriage is replaced by a culture where individuals choose their own mates, divorce rates start to climb. It's happening right now in China, where the national divorce rate is steadily escalating. An estimated 2.87 million Chinese marriages ended in 2012. That's only 2.2 percent, but just 30 years ago the nation's divorce rate was *.04 percent*. That means out of 10,000